CS 250 Module Six Journal: Agile Communication

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Practices that lead to maximum openness in a Scrum Team are practices where the same information is provided to all participants of the process. An information radiator, such as a task board or a burndown chart, is placed in the location visible to all the team members, and no one needs to request a status update to know the position of the Sprint. Sticking a card into the same column for three days provides a message to the team about the problems that have emerged even without verbalization. According to Deneir (2023), transparency is achieved when there is a common understanding of the work by the team, and updating the Sprint Backlog whenever the team member started an item, finished an item, or blocked an item allows knowing in advance whether the Sprint Goal is at risk.

The Scrum events provide the schedule on top of that visibility. During the Daily Scrum, the Developers assess the current position in the achievement of the Sprint Goal and make plans for the following day. As Banica (2024) argues, the focus on the Sprint Goal and keeping the event short make it easy to notice the impediment in time, and the solution of the problem needs to be discussed in another discussion after the meeting. The Sprint Review presents to the Product Owner and to stakeholders the actual result of the Sprint allowing to make the feedback based on the real product. The Sprint Retrospective provides the scheduled opportunity to discuss teamwork and collaboration within the team. Thus, fewer assumptions need to be filled by the participants of the process.

The most obvious example from the SNHU Travel assignment occurred in Module Four when I performed the role of the tester. My user stories contained the acceptance criteria for saved preferences, personalized top destinations list, and vacation-type filters but there were

some gaps in them. None of the criteria contained numerical limits and in personalized top destinations list story the description for unlikely destinations was given as exclusion or lower priority, but without any explanation of how this decision was supposed to be made. Instead of making assumptions, I asked Christy, the Product Owner, the specific questions. Her reply contained a wireframe for a slideshow showing one destination on every slide with Previous and Next buttons. This approach implied a change in the user behavior on the website, thus I needed to revise every test case even though the criteria remained the same. Also, the new questions were raised, including what should be shown on every slide and what should be seen after the last destination, which I asked for in writing form. Since I asked the question prior to any coding based on those test cases, the cost was a simple revision of the written test cases.

Similarly, in Module Five, being the developer, I emailed Christy and the tester, asking for their replies before the Daily Scrum and mentioning that I will write down each decision into the backlog item. One of the questions that I asked, namely, what Next should do on the last slide was derived from the test case that I composed as the tester and working in two roles helped me to ask the better question. As the navigation through the slideshow already worked, I only needed to replace the content. The most effective practice in this case was asking the specific questions in writing form before the work on the development was started. Recording the answers where they can be accessed by the whole team played an equally important role.

The use of an Agile project management tool simplifies this type of communication. In the course of a year and a half, Berntzen et al. (2023) analyzed a large software company and identified such tools as Jira and Slack, together with task boards and product backlogs, as the coordination mechanisms that can complement the meetings and team roles. Azure Boards demonstrates how it works for a single team. It hosts the Product Backlog, Sprint Plans, and the

boards in one place, and every user story or task becomes a work item with its own history of changes (Microsoft, 2025). If Christy's answer regarding the slideshow had been placed on the work item of the corresponding user story instead of sending it in an email, the tester and the developers could access it without forwarding it. The work items may be linked to commits, branches, and pull requests so that the defect discovered in the course of testing may be traced back to the changes made. The team members may @mention each other on the work item and get notifications about any changes to it. Dashboards show the current progress without any need for creating separate status reports (Microsoft, 2025). On a five-week project like SNHU Travel, less time will be needed for searching for the decisions and status updates, and the time may be spent on building and testing the product instead.

References

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